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Player to watch **RAHMANULLAH GURBAZ**

At 23 years old, Rahmanullah Gurbaz has become a constant fixture in the Afghanistan white-ball setup and T20 franchise teams across the globe. In 46 ODIs so far, the opener has scored 1,769 runs at an average of 39.31 and a healthy strike rate of 88.49.

The keeper-batter's fast starts in the PowerPlay and his partnership with Ibrahim Zadran helped Afghanistan reach the T20 World Cup semifinals last year. The team will be hoping for more of the same this time round.

franchise teams he represents.

Afghanistan's fast bowling resources display a variety that makes them potent too. Azmatullah Omarzai's proficiency with the new ball will help the team make early inroads in the PowerPlay, while Fazalhaq Farooqi, who finished as the highest wicket-taker in the 2024 T20 World Cup, will come into play during both extremities of the game.

The left-arm seamer can swing the ball early on and also vary the pace towards the back end of the innings to prise out wickets.

Afghanistan's only possible weakness could be its inability to put

up totals higher than 300 on the board, especially during a chase. The team has managed to win only one of ten matches where it was required to chase down a 300-plus total.

Afghanistan will take on South Africa, England, and Australia in Group B, with its matches taking place in Karachi and Lahore.

If the team is welcomed by its neighbour with flat pitches, the onus will fall on the batting core to rise to the occasion.

However, if there is a hint of turn on offer, expect Afghanistan to give the other three teams a run for their money.

SQUAD

Hashmatullah Shahidi (c), Ibrahim Zadran, Rahmanullah Gurbaz, Sediqullah Atal, Rahmat Shah, Ikram Alikhil, Gulbadin Naib, Azmatullah Omarzai, Mohammad Nabi, Rashid Khan, AM Ghazanfar, Noor Ahmad, Fazalhaq Farooqi, Farid Malik, Naveed Zadran